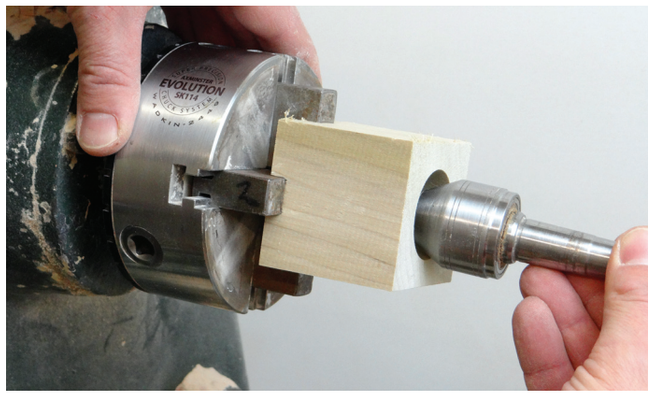
What if I don't own a fancy live centre?

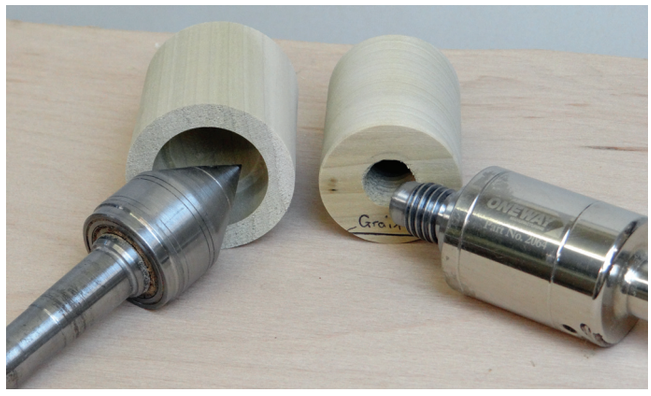
If you don't have this sort of centre, it isn't a problem because you can turn a similar version to sit over your live centre to do the same job. The process is similar to making a box, in that you hold the blank in the chuck and turn out the inside, deep enough to accommodate the live centre and to a diameter that is a tight push fit over the parallel section of the live centre. At this point you can mount it and drive it between centres as I described for the threaded version. The main difference here is the grain direction, because the threaded version is cross grain, which means turning it needs a little more care and the use of a spindle gouge to cut it cleanly, but the standard push fit version will be end grain and can be simply turned, as a spindle, with a roughing gouge.

Turning out the hollow for the live centre to fit, using the wing of the gouge, just like hollowing a box



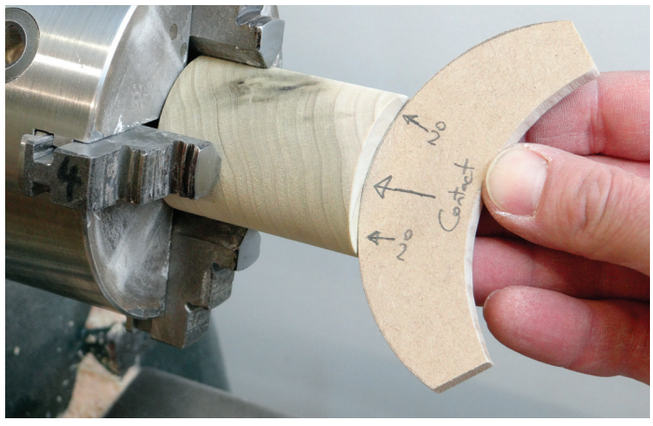
MDF template cut to the radius of the sphere

Truing the blank for the cup with it fitted on the live centre and driven by a drive centre

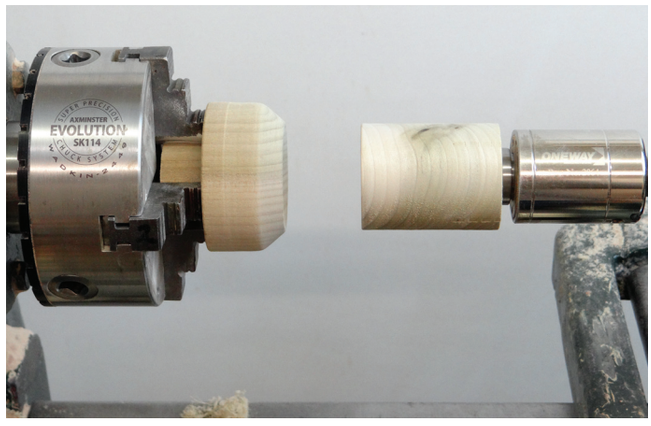


Both types of live centre with the wooden cup fittings for driving the sphere

Once the fitting is made and turned true, mount it in the chuck and turn a cup shape into the face. Again the grain direction is relevant here, as the cross grain version will need turning from the rim down to the bottom, like a bowl, where the end grain version will need drawing out from the centre to the rim with the wing of the tool like a box. The exact shape of the cup is important here; too deep and only the rim will drive the ball, which will certainly leave ring-shaped dents in the sphere. You need to turn the cup slightly too shallow, which means that a good proportion of the bottom of the cup will drive the sphere, but importantly the rim won't come into contact, leaving the sphere blemish free. To achieve this, I cut out the same radius curve on the other side of the template and turn the cup to suit, ensuring the rim doesn't come into contact with the template, and so the sphere.



Use a template to turn the correct shaped cup. Ensure it isn't too deep so the rim can't damage the sphere as it drives



Wooden cups, ready for action

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